

■ By Ramesh Vinayak

Afghanistan has long been a supplier of dry fruits to India but lately the war-torn nation is also exporting another commodity, heroin, though clandestinely through Pakistan. With Afghanistan harvesting a bumper poppy crop for the second successive year, heroin—a derivative of opium and known as “white gold” among narcotic peddlers because of the high price it fetches in international markets—is finding its way in larger quantities in the country.

Law enforcement agencies in Punjab, Jammu and Rajasthan have intercepted about 465 kg of heroin in the first-half of 2008, which is roughly a fivefold increase over the corresponding period of 2007. “Seizures have increased because there is more stuff flowing from Pakistan,” says Saji Mohan, zonal director, Narcotics Control Bureau (NCB), Chandigarh.

Sandwiched between the world’s two biggest sources of illicit drugs—the Golden Crescent (Pakistan, Afghanistan and Iran) and the Golden Triangle (Myanmar, Thailand and Laos), India has traditionally been a transit point for drug trafficking to Europe and North America. At 6,610 metric tonne in 2007, heroin production in Afghanistan has registered a 43 per cent rise over that of 2006 and helps fund the Taliban war machine. Despite the massive output, international demand for the drug remains stable, leading to huge stockpiles in Afghanistan and Pakistan. “Arrested smugglers have revealed that drug producers on the Afghanistan-Pakistan border are supplying heroin even on credit,” says Jagdish Mittal, DIG, Counter-Intelligence and in-charge of the Special Narcotic Cell (SNC), Punjab Police.

NCB officials say nearly 70 per cent of Afghan heroin is smuggled to West Asia and Europe via Iran, while the rest is trafficked through Pakistan and India. Indian agencies are alarmed by reports that suggest a new form of narco-terrorism wherein smuggled heroin could be used for bankrolling anti-India terror outfits in Pakistan and Bangladesh.

Another worrisome trend is the patronage that drug traffickers are getting from the police and politicians. An internal note on the drug menace in Punjab

Photographs by PRABHUOT GILL



HEROIN HAVEN

With traffickers forming a nexus with the police and politicians, the state, which has become a transit point for trans-border peddling, is in the grip of a rampant drug menace

by the state police graphically drives home the worst kept secret: “The perusal of interrogation reports of smugglers since 1998 reveals that many police officials are involved in helping the drug trade by taking bribes from smugglers”. This was highlighted in

March with the arrest of Parshotam Lal Sondhi, a youth leader of the ruling Shiromani Akali Dal (SAD), while carrying a 23-kg heroin consignment for delivery to a Canada-bound passenger at the Amritsar International airport. Sondhi is known to have financed SAD in